

OPTIMIZE BEFORE YOU AUTOMATE

Automation scales whatever you give it. Hand it a broken process and you get a faster broken process: you digitize the waste. SOAS is the order that stops that. Each stage earns the right to start the next.

S Standardize

O Optimize

A Automate

S Sustain

1 Standardize

Can we run the process the same way every time?

- Write the standard work with the people who do the job, then check they follow it.
- Give the process one owner. Define each data field and where it comes from.

Trap: a procedure on paper that nobody on the floor actually follows.

OUTPUT

One agreed way of working, one owner, data fields you can trust.

2 Optimize

Should every step in this process even exist?

- Map it, then cut the waste: waiting, rework, handoffs, duplicate checks.
- Reduce variation, and find the real constraint before anyone proposes a tool.

Trap: treating today's steps as requirements for the new system.

OUTPUT

A leaner process map and a named constraint.

3 Automate

Where does technology or AI add value now?

- Automate the repetitive work. Use AI to augment decisions and spot patterns.
- Aim it at the constraint you found in step 2, not at the loudest complaint.

Trap: buying the tool first, then looking for a process to fit it.

OUTPUT

A scoped use case tied to one constraint and one measure.

4 Sustain

Who owns the new way of working?

- Set the measures, the review rhythm and who acts when a number drifts.
- Train the frontline and build in feedback, so the people who use it can improve it.

Trap: go-live is treated as the finish line, and the project team walks away.

OUTPUT

An owner, a measure, a review rhythm and a feedback loop.

The rule: never automate a process you haven't optimized. AI should be the accelerator, not the repair shop. If a stage isn't done, the next stage inherits its problems, only faster.



EVERY STAGE HAS AN EXIT GATE

Don't move on because the calendar says so. Move on when the evidence says the stage is done.

STAGE	DONE WHEN	EVIDENCE TO ASK FOR
Standardize	Different people run it the same way, and the data means the same thing every time.	Standard work signed off by the people who do the job; a data dictionary with an owner.
Optimize	The obvious waste is gone and you know which step limits the flow.	A before/after process map; the constraint named, with how it was measured.
Automate	The tool removes the constraint, and the result is measured against a baseline.	The baseline, the target measure, and a pilot result on real work.
Sustain	The gain holds after the project team leaves.	A named owner, a review on the calendar, and a response plan for drift.

WORKED EXAMPLE: BATCH RECORD REVIEW ILLUSTRATIVE EXAMPLE

STAGE	WHAT THE TEAM FOUND	WHAT THEY DID
The request	"Use AI to review batch records faster."	Ran the SOAS test before approving it.
Standardize	Each shift recorded comments differently; one field meant two things.	One template, one definition per field, one process owner.
Optimize	Records waited in a queue for a second check that repeated the first.	Removed the duplicate check; the real constraint was late corrections.
Automate	Most review time went on finding the same recurring gaps.	AI flags missing or out-of-range entries; the reviewer still decides.
Sustain	Without an owner, the template would drift back.	QA owns the template; flagged gaps are reviewed every month.

SELF-CHECK: SIGNS YOU ARE AUTOMATING TOO EARLY

- ☐ Two shifts do the same job two different ways
- ☐ Nobody can say who owns the process end to end
- ☐ People fix the data by hand before it's used
- ☐ The business case names a tool before a problem
- ☐ No one has mapped the process in the last year
- ☐ There's no baseline to measure the tool against
- ☐ The plan ends at go-live
- ☐ Users first see the tool at training

Two or more ticks? Go back to the earliest stage that's not done, and start there.

AI CAN HELP BEFORE THE AUTOMATE STAGE, TOO

STAGE	AI DOES THE LEGWORK	PEOPLE KEEP
Standardize	Groups how people log the same event; flags fields used two ways	Agreeing the one standard
Optimize	Reads timestamps to show where work waits and loops back	Deciding which steps to cut
Automate	Does the repetitive work; flags patterns for a person to judge	The decision and the sign-off
Sustain	Watches the measure and flags drift early	Acting on the drift

THE SOAS TEST: SCORE ONE REQUEST

Take the next automation or AI request on your desk. Score it with the process owner, before anyone opens a vendor deck.

THE PROCESS AND THE REQUEST

THE CONSTRAINT IT CLAIMS TO SOLVE

SCORE EACH QUESTION: 0 = NO · 1 = PARTLY · 2 = YES, WITH EVIDENCE

STAGE	QUESTION	SCORE	EVIDENCE	OWNER · DATE
Standardize	Is the process standardized?	012		
Standardize	Is the data trustworthy?	012		
Optimize	Have we cut the obvious waste?	012		
Automate	Does it solve a real constraint?	012		
Sustain	Who owns the results after launch?	012		

DECISION

☐ **Fix first**
Any 0. Close the gap at the earliest stage that scored 0.

☐ **Pilot only**
No 0s, some 1s. Pilot with every gap owned and dated.

☐ **Approve**
All 2s. Automate, and set the Sustain plan below.

SUSTAIN PLAN

ITEM	OUR ANSWER
Owner after launch	
The measure and its baseline	
Review rhythm (who, how often)	
What triggers a re-check	

TRY THIS WEEK

Score one live automation request with its process owner. If it gets a 0, don't reject it: name the stage to fix, give it an owner and a date, and bring it back.